



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 32

NEW JERSEY

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside New Jersey's family courts and child-welfare system.

43

NEW JERSEY FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
69 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 8, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

15 OF 21

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

NEW JERSEY AT A GLANCE.

Across 43 New Jersey families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 69 42 of 43 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$325,500 median across 19 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 60.5% 37.2% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 43	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 42 of 43	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 15

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so New Jersey families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF NEW JERSEY FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	28	\$40,000	\$86,650	\$2,426,200
Lost Wages	23	\$20,000	\$76,374	\$1,756,600
Other Court Fees	21	\$4,000	\$39,743	\$834,600
Therapy / Evaluations	22	\$4,250	\$12,680	\$278,950
Reunification Services	14	\$0	\$5,143	\$72,000
GAL Fees	15	\$0	\$7,900	\$118,500
Asset Loss ¹	23	\$100,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (19 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$325,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$100,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Total across all families		608	50.7 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · NEW JERSEY

Most families documenting in New Jersey are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		17	40%
Active case: stuck or delayed		13	30%
Active case: progress being made		4	9%
Case closed: within last 2 years		3	7%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		2	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only		17	40%
Both Family Court and CPS		17	40%
Unknown		7	16%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		1	2%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

Over 10 years		10	23%
1 – 3 years		9	21%
5 – 10 years		7	16%
3 – 5 years		7	16%
5+ years		4	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

50/50 Joint		17	40%
Visitation Only		9	21%
Full Custody		7	16%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		5	12%
Partial / Shared		4	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Morris		5	12%
Bergen		3	7%
Camden		2	5%
Gloucester		2	5%
Atlantic		2	5%
Somerset		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		14	33%
High Conflict Divorce		8	19%
Other: (Short answer)		5	12%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		3	7%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		3	7%

04 PARENT VOICES — NEW JERSEY

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable New Jersey comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Institutional Betrayed my children and myself with fake justice and no interest in being impartial. I am deaf Latina who doesn't speak English our abuser is deaf American born but nevertheless court has allowed his paralegal wife interfere and participate for him fully even [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Took my children away based on a biased report without due process, dismissing the documented abuse. Permitted post separation abuse in the court for over a decade

— NEW JERSEY PARENT · COLLEEN

MORE VOICES FROM NEW JERSEY

Child support against my constitution rights tl with no jurisdiction and. hey're went against and siderb with false dyfs calls

— JOEY

Allowed a known abuser to put a survivor on the street and cause homelessness and take her children who endured every ounce of the abuse with her and leave them in the care of the person who caused the trauma and now uses them to exploit others, as weapons to hurt their mother [...]

— CATHERINE

Family court is criminal, destroyed my family, with no contact to my 2 grown children who still live with their father who is a lawyer. I learned family court law, wrote my own motions after 5 years of over \$100,000+ wasted on both sides and became ProSe.

— LORI

Made me financially bankrupt living in a vehicle 3 years fighting for my kids and home I'm just a visiting father friend after 15 years of marriage and 7 years I was stayed home Dad and she fraud me she cheat on me she adultery criminal activity and her lawyers defending it and [...]

— RAYIF ATAY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The court took my two little best friends and tried to turn them against me! It's destroying parents but siblings too!

— AMANDA

I was threatened by CPS that they would take my children for neglect if I didn't leave the physically abusive marriage, and when I left and filed a restraining order, the Court forced visitation that was "supervised" by his brother. I now have to send my youngest child to visit [...]

— KRISTIN

Due process violations, fraud upon the court, open theft of assets. Protective parent targeted because I refused to sign away my children as wards of the state.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court has utterly failed my children and has purposefully ruined all of our lives to ensure they grow up in an unstable, unhappy environment.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Torn US apart - separated us I was a stay at home Mother housewife and homemaker.

— BARBARA

I thought the court system is meant to protect us, but it did the contrary, it destroyed us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Lost my home, 2 businesses, career, daughter now 11 in treatments for AMPS which can't be cured and primary compromised immune system so can't be in school. My child's life was destroyed with blatant lies, perjury, and malicious acts.

— CARRIE

No enforcement, judge stated multiple times "why is this case never settled. I'm not dealing with child support enforcement. Figure it out." Divorced with a 4 page binding agreement and no MSA. The judge would make a decision with a court order that would never be addressed in [...]

— ROBIN

Separated all of us from each other

— LISA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system treated me, Their mother as a criminal. Although Instead of innocent until proven guilty: I was treated guilty and went bankrupt trying to prove my innocence. Truth didn't matter neither did the wellbeing of my kids.

— KRISTA

My son was mercilessly kidnapped I lost my son for 4 years put into kinship placement with out my knowledge

— MAUREEN

Defamation of character and the introduction of the system to my 5 year old only based on anonymous retaliatory allegations

— THERESA

Vetting lawyers is challenging. Make sure you vet them. Don't get older lawyers who say the right thing but are jaded

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Profited off defamation, and never looked at evidence

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Created extensive delay of divorce with a high conflict other parent who continues their abuse post-separation. The marriage was emotionally, mentally abusive(& more), and the court allows him to continue abuse via financial and manipulation, due to the court's lack of action.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They don't look at my evidence I've been begging court that we can't coparent for years and they told me we need to learn however, my ex does not want to hate me and uses the kids as weapons

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Broken us and broken a beautiful boy away from a loving fully dedicated mother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

As a resource parent for kin for my sister, this court failed us from every side of the situation. Never once tried to help reunify the family. Drove me to my breaking point and questioned me when I wanted answers. Intimidated my family and took all my sense of privacy. Priced [...]

— NICOLE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system is being very biased. I explain to the court how the child is being used as a weapon to hurt me by the other party & they are doing nothing about it. I try to request more time other party objects and the court granted her objection. I been the one filing for 4 years [...]

— CHRISITAN

They have allowed my x to violate the court orders without consequence. Allowed him to retain shared custodies to continue to tell the children lies about me to place them in the middle of litigations and attempt to turn them against me and make their entire childhood an attack [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

System allows people to become bankrupt by assigned all of these unnecessary evaluators and professionals. No cap on fees and no oversight and no guard rails for these unscrupulous individuals to get rich. It is appalling that they have such power over children and families [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed the well bring and emotion state of my family. It has completely alienated my daughter from me and forced my oldest son to be alienated from his father and his family. It has systematically broken us. We live in constant PTSD and live to defend and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is so skewed for people with higher income or those who know someone in the courts or have some sort of power of their own. Poor, hard working people usually pay dearly, well off people that are abusive do not.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

29 New Jersey parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 29 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — NEW JERSEY

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from New Jersey families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Institutional Betrayed my children and myself with fake justice and no interest in being impartial. I am deaf Latina who doesn't speak English our abuser is deaf American born but nevertheless court has allowed his paralegal wife interfere and participate for him fully even though there are proof in writing that texts in app court are not his, nor long email with legal jargon to parent coordinators. In court his appearance are brief and fall short of his long demanding perjury claims on me. But nobody cares. I have requested to go onto mediation in court as both of us are in front of interpreter and mediator and his tantrums don't work and we are able to move on because his paralegal wife is not there to coach him but firstly attorneys don't want to suggest it and judge said they rather us to work it out outside court. But this leave us to the escalation of issues from our abuser for everything and for minimal it could be because he thrive in coercive control and litigation. He has told our children he will never stop fighting me until they are out of family court system and discouraged them to pursue college or university studies as he JW and wants them to go to mission and get married.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Child support against my constitution rights tl with no jurisdiction and. hey're went against and siderb with false dyfs calls

— JOEY

Allowed a known abuser to put a survivor on the street and cause homelessness and take her children who endured every ounce of the abuse with her and leave them in the care of the person who caused the trauma and now uses them to exploit others, as weapons to hurt their mother, his image to cover the years of abuse and substance use, took my entire life and discard me like garbage when he didn't need anything anymore than dismantled my entire life, discredited my parenting and smeared my name. Rebuilt my entire life and he lied lied lied again to forced our children back into his care with an active temporary restraining order!!!!!!

— CATHERINE

Took my children away based on a biased report without due process, dismissing the documented abuse. Permitted post separation abuse in the court for over a decade

— COLLEEN

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Family court is criminal, destroyed my family, with no contact to my 2 grown children who still live with their father who is a lawyer. I learned family court law, wrote my own motions after 5 years of over \$100,000+ wasted on both sides and became ProSe.

— LORI

Made me financially bankrupt living in a vehicle 3 years fighting for my kids and home I'm just a visiting father friend after 15 years of marriage and 7 years I was stayed home Dad and she fraud me she cheat on me she adultery criminal activity and her lawyers defending it and judge been favoring her lawyer

— RAYIF ATAY

The court took my two little best friends and tried to turn them against me! It's destroying parents but siblings too!

— AMANDA

I was threatened by CPS that they would take my children for neglect if I didn't leave the physically abusive marriage, and when I left and filed a restraining order, the Court forced visitation that was "supervised" by his brother. I now have to send my youngest child to visit her abusive father, and have to spend thousands of dollars divorcing him, and attempting to get normal child support since the restraining order judge refused to review any of my evidence for support, or child safety.

— KRISTIN

Due process violations, fraud upon the court, open theft of assets. Protective parent targeted because I refused to sign away my children as wards of the state.

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Lost my home, 2 businesses, career, daughter now 11 in treatments for AMPS which can't be cured and primary compromised immune system so can't be in school. My child's life was destroyed with blatant lies, perjury, and malicious acts.

— CARRIE

No enforcement, judge stated multiple times "why is this case never settled. I'm not dealing with child support enforcement. Figure it out." Divorced with a 4 page binding agreement and no MSA. The judge would make a decision with a court order that would never be addressed in future court orders. There was never discovery completed by my ex. My daughters are currently manipulated by my ex and is actively sabotaging my relationship with our 12 yr old triplet daughters. There has been communication between my ex and children telling them to "do what you need to do" to me to get me to comply with his orders.

— ROBIN

Separated all of us from each other

— LISA

The system treated me, Their mother as a criminal. Although Instead of innocent until proven guilty: I was treated guilty and went bankrupt trying to prove my innocence. Truth didn't matter neither did the wellbeing of my kids.

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As a resource parent for kin for my sister, this court failed us from every side of the situation. Never once tried to help reunify the family. Drove me to my breaking point and questioned me when I wanted answers. Intimidated my family and took all my sense of privacy. Priced my nephews out like they were cattle by their age and weight like I was impressed by a price tag children. Fueled my determination to expose them.

— NICOLE

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system is being very biased. I explain to the court how the child is being used as a weapon to hurt me by the other party & they are doing nothing about it. I try to request more time other party objects and the court granted her objection. I been the one filing for 4 years and the other party is always talking about my personal life and mentioning how she do not want my fiancée to post my child on social media with out the court finding any harm. Judge Tiscornia still put that as an order mind you the other party never filed for that. This was a case I filed for. The system is being very unfair. Things keep getting worse and the court keeps enforing me to speak to the other parent despite the fact that they disrespect me.

— CHRISITAN

They have allowed my x to violate the court orders without consequence. Allowed him to retain shared custodies to continue to tell the children lies about me to place them in the middle of litigations and attempt to turn them against me and make their entire childhood an attack on me to validate his narrative to the end of our relationship.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

System allows people to become bankrupt by assigned all of these unnecessary evaluators and professionals. No cap on fees and no oversight and no guard rails for these unscrupulous individuals to get rich. It is appalling that they have such power over children and families while not following the law, bankrupting and colluding

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed the well bring and emotion state of my family. It has completely alienated my daughter from me and forced my oldest son to be alienated from his father and his family. It has systematically broken us. We live in constant PTSD and live to defend and protect ourselves. There is no peace. It is now daily attacks. It is not sustainable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is so skewed for people with higher income or those who know someone in the courts or have some sort of power of their own. Poor, hard working people usually pay dearly, well off people that are abusive do not.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

29 full approved New Jersey comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this New Jersey report comes from New Jersey respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in New Jersey — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 43 New Jersey families reporting here are not the universe of New Jersey families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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